

BEFORE

Decades of war in Europe resulted in advances in military tactics and techniques, although the development of improved weaponry was slow to follow.

BATTLE-READY

The 30 Years War (1618–48) << 262–63 put Europe on an all-out war footing. Innovative tactics were employed by field commanders, and training manuals, maps, and field glasses began to be more widely used. But the idea of a permanent or “standing” professional army as a fixed piece of machinery of state (just like the nonmilitary civil service) was still in its infancy.

TECHNOLOGY OF WAR

Despite the fact that gunpowder had been developed 400 years before << 162–63, it remained highly volatile and liable to explode at any time. The copper and bronze weaponry made to fire it was slow in development and far from uniform in design or ammunition. Cannons varied in size and were classified by ball weight, the largest being referred to as the “90-pounder.” Giant cannons known as bombards could weigh 5 tons (4,500 kg) and throw an iron ball nearly half a mile (1 km). These cannons were useful for demolishing fortifications.

Stalemate

The Four Days’ Battle was fought on June 11–14, 1666 as part of the Second Anglo-Dutch War, (1665–67). It was fought at close quarters between an English fleet of 56 ships under the Duke of Albemarle and a larger Dutch fleet commanded by their great admiral Michiel De Ruyter.

**Battle with pikes**

As military tactics became more sophisticated, full-on cavalry charges and standardized artillery became integral to more sustained and offensive tactics than the older pike-style warfare, shown above.

During the 17th century, Europe became an almost permanent theater of war, witnessing more battles than in any other place or time. If there was a dispute to settle, then war was the way to do it—diplomacy came when treaties were made.

From the late 17th century, trade—not religion or dynasty—became the dominant cause of conflict between Europeans. The nascent nation-states were increasingly concerned about their freedoms to trade, and thereby to profit and to protect monopolies both on the high seas and in overseas possessions. This became the dominant factor in state formation.

Quarrels about trade around the world were now a concern of European states-in-the-making. For example, from 1652 to 1674, two former

republican allies—England and the Dutch Republic—embarked on three Anglo-Dutch Wars centered around trade, colonial possessions, and shipping rights. France and Denmark also entered the conflicts periodically.

The initial cause was an act passed by the English parliament that forbade any foreign ship to carry, and therefore trade, English goods. The Dutch carried massive quantities of English goods in their ships, which made them huge profits that they were prepared to fight to protect. The Treaty of Breda (1667), which ended the second Anglo-Dutch War, was the first multinational peace settlement, concerned as much about Europe’s overseas interests as its European boundaries. Significantly, the wide-ranging Peace of Westphalia that had ended the 30 Years War

Masters of War

By the 18th century, Europe had emerged from a series of violent wars fought over religion. Such conflicts were quickly replaced with battles over trade rights both in Europe and in the ever-increasing number of European colonies abroad. The increasing sophistication of military tactics across the continent outpaced advances in artillery design and production.

KING OF SWEDEN (1594–1632)**GUSTAVUS ADOLPHUS II**

Gustavus Adolphus II came to the throne of Sweden in 1611 and is considered the father of modern military tactics. He promoted a more standardized and much lighter artillery, more compact supply trains, offensive tactics (a quick offensive campaign gave the enemy little time to prepare its defense), and provisioning troops by negotiation, not looting. To achieve this he needed well-trained and disciplined troops, and Gustavus ensured that his men were regularly paid. His military innovations in troop formations and combinations led to a permanent increase in the size of European armies. Sweden was a major power in Europe by the time of his death.

